LECTURE 5: READING SKILLS

Welcome once again to the 5th lecture on reading skills.

Questions for reflections

Do you read every book from beginning to end? At the same speed? What strategies do you use to make sure you understand the meaning and recall the important points?

How effective a reader are you? That is, how often do you need to go back and re-read in order to understand and retain important information

Introduction

Reading is going to be an essential element during the course of your university studies. This is not only because reading is a principal means of obtaining information, expanding your knowledge and understanding of your subjects but also because a large proportion of your time of study will be spent working with written sources of information and because you have to cover a great deal of material in a short amount of time. For these reasons it is essential that you develop a reading capability that is both purposeful and efficient. People generally tend to assume that "everyone knows how to read", the truth is that not everyone does and those who do are often not reading as effectively as they should be.

Reading is a skill that you need to learn, develop, and craft it. One of the benefits of reading is that it will keep your a mind alive, and progressive.

Therefore, here is a word of advice: ***If you want to live a very active, progressive, life throughout, then there should be no end point to reading.***

This lecture intends to provide you with guidelines that will turn you into a more effective reader

Learning Objectives

At the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Define with understanding concepts of reading
- Discuss the benefits of reading for students

- Identify the purpose of reading
- Apply various strategies to read different texts
- Identify the factors that affect reading skills
- Apply guidelines to effective reading
- Apply the SQ3R reading model

The Meaning and Nature of Reading

Reading has been conceptualized in a number of ways. Let us look at some of these definitions of reading.

Wixson *et al.* (1987) defined reading as the process of constructing meaning through the dynamic interaction of:-

- The reader's existing knowledge
- The information suggested by the text being read
- The context of the reading situation

According to Wikipedia, reading is a way of getting information from something that is written. It is a process that involves recognizing the symbols that make up language

According to Fedeles (2012), reading is the translation of symbols, or letters, into words and sentences that then have meaning for the individual looking at them. The reader must follow a sequence of symbols arranged in a particular way - in English from left to right, in Hebrew from right to left and in Chinese from top to bottom.

Considering all the definitions above, reading can be said to be a complex cognitive process of decoding symbols in order to construct or derive meaning (reading comprehension).

It is a means of language acquisition, of communication, and of sharing information and ideas. Like all language, it is a complex interaction between the text and the reader which is shaped by the reader's prior knowledge, experiences, attitude, and language

community which is culturally and socially situated. The reading process requires continuous practice, development and refinement.

For words that are in a reader's meaning vocabulary, unlocking the pronunciation leads to the word's meaning. If a printed word is not in a reader's meaning vocabulary, word-identification skills may allow access to the word's pronunciation, but not its meaning. Being able to arrive at the pronunciation of a printed word constitutes word identification in the most minimal sense; however, if the reader is unable to attach meaning to the word, then he or she has not read the word, since reading must end in meaning construction.

Benefits of reading

- Educational researchers have found that there is a strong correlation between reading and academic success - a student who is a good reader is more likely to do well in school and pass exams than a student who is a weak reader. Good readers can understand the individual sentences and the organizational structure of a piece of writing. They can comprehend ideas, follow arguments and detect implications.

  Your reading skill is a very critical factor responsible for increasing your ability to learn and master large volumes of information. Thus, your ability to read fast gives you an edge over others by making it possible for you to go through piles of papers quickly.

- Educational researchers have also found a strong correlation between reading and vocabulary knowledge. In other words, students who have a large vocabulary are usually good readers. This is not very surprising, since the best way to acquire a large vocabulary is to read extensively, and if you read extensively you are likely to be or become a good reader!

Why Reading is Important for Students

Here are some benefits of reading for students:

1. Giving Satisfaction.
2. Enhancing Concentration.
3. Imparting Knowledge.
4. Exercise of Brain.
5. Reducing Stress.
6. Enhancing Analytical Thinking.
7. Improving Vocabulary.
8. Improving Writing Skills.

Let us elaborate further on these benefits:

1. Giving Satisfaction

Reading gives great satisfaction to the readers. A popular phrase "curling up with books" creates an image of a warm and close relationship with the book.

Even parents feel satisfied when they see their kids are reading books.

2. Enhancing Concentration

For reading one needs to be focused for a longer duration and it requires mental exercise. For understanding the text or the whole story, the reader must concentrate his mind on a particular matter.

In this way, reading improves our concentration power and focus.

3. Imparting Knowledge

Reading enhances the knowledge of the readers.

By developing the reading skills, the readers can diversify their field of knowledge which provides them with the chance to participate in fruitful discussion and decision-making processes.

4. Exercise of Brain

Reading is regarded as an exercise of the brain.

When we involved in reading our brain cells start to work for understanding the meaning of the text and try to relate various aspects of the matter read.
Thus reading stimulates the brain and impels it to think about all possible aspects for realizing the meaning.

5. Reducing Stress

Reading is a great habit that can change human lives dramatically. It can entertain us; amuse us and enrich us with knowledge.
It helps us reducing stress, relieving tensions and thus boosts our energy. It carries us to the realm of dream and amusement – far away from the real complex world.

6. Enhancing Analytical Thinking

Reading not only enriches your knowledge but also makes it sharpen to analyze and evaluate things in a better way.
In this way, reading enhances our analytical thinking.

7. Improving Vocabulary

Skilful reading increases the vocabulary of the readers by introducing them with the new and unfamiliar words and phrases regularly.
It not only enriches our vocabulary but also teaches us a better way of expressing ourselves.

8. Improving Writing Skills

Reading helps gradual improvements in vocabulary that in turn enhances the reader's writing skills.
As it boosts the ability to think, it also improves the written expression.

Purpose for reading

Why do we read?

Readers use text differently depending on the types of text and their purpose for reading. The following are some of the reasons for reading:

a) ***Reading for pleasure/entertainment***

Many people today complain about loneliness. A book or some other reading material provides very good company without the demands on your life that we associate with a friend's company. While reading for entertainment, you will get some information. The reading will therefore have served a duel purpose. The materials that are read for pleasure are: novels , storybooks, cartoons, magazines, sections of newspapers and many others.

b) ***Acquiring knowledge and information***

If your read widely on all subjects, you will be more and better informed. It has been rightly said that or "knowledge is power". If you have good knowledge about issues or on how to do things, you will certainly be successful in you endeavours. Good general knowledge will also help to socialise with people from all walks of life. Try to read widely on all emerging issues bee they social, cultural, economic, political or technical. A lot of information on a wide variety of issues is currently being circulated via internet. You need to learn how to use the internet so that you can access the information, retrieve and read it.

c) ***Reading for academic purpose***

The university is the place where the highest level of learning takes place. University students, their lecturers and other scholars are avid readers-often referred to a academicians. Students are expected to master knowledge in their subjects. To attain this mastery, they need to read very widely on the subjects, conduct library research, analyse information and report on it in form of term papers. This way, you create further reading materials and hence knowledge. Materials that can be read for academic information are: textbooks, reference books, general and specialist journals, magazines and special sections of newspapers.

d) Reading for instructions or directions

We are living in the 'do it yourself' age. Manufacturers of goods of all sorts carefully prepare operational manuals and package them with the goods. It is necessary tha the users who will buy those goods are able to read and follow instructions for maximum benefit. At one time or another, you will be such a user. You therefore need to be a keen and effective reader.

Factors Affecting Reading Skills

There are various factors which affect reading speed; comprehension ability and overall reading efficiency of a person vary from person to person. Though Here are some of the factors which may affect reading:

- **Educational background**: A well-educated person may have a higher reading efficiency than one who is a literate.
- **Physical capability**: Sometimes, some physical defect in some persons may hinder their efficiency to read and comprehend.
- **Mental capability**: People have different mental capabilities. While some are born intellectuals, others acquire intelligence through their efforts. A higher mental capability will definitely lead to a better reading efficiency and retention.
- **Interest:** If the reader finds reading material interesting, he will definitely read it faster, understand it and retain it for a longer time. On the other hand, if the reading material is boring or not of interest to the reader, his efficiency will be hindered accordingly.
- **Practice:** Reading speed is a by-product of practice and time spent on reading. Avid readers enhance their reading skills by stepping up their reading. It is rightly said, "Practice makes a man perfect."

Types of reading

Reading may be classified into four main categories as explained below:

Scanning - this is looking or running your eyes over a text quickly to get a specific piece of information. Move your eyes quickly over the page to find particular words, name or phrases that are relevant to the task you are doing. For instance, when you want to find out whether you are in the list of the students who will progress to second year, do you go reading all the 200 names written there? DEFINITELY NO. Instead, you use your

finger or just eyes to run through the text to find what you are looking for. That process is called scanning.

Uses of scanning

- There are many areas where the use of scanning would be of necessary importance. First, reading off a computer screen has become a growing concern. Research shows that people have more difficulty reading off a computer screen than off paper. Although they can read and comprehend at the same rate as on paper, scanning on the computer is much slower than on paper.
- Similarly, scanning skills are valuable for students studying at university level. First, they are an aid in locating new terms, which are introduced in the chapter. Unless you understand the new terms, it is impossible to follow the author's reasoning without a dictionary or glossary. Thus a preliminary scanning of the chapters will alert you to the new terms and their sequence. When you locate a new term, try to find its definition. If you are not able to figure out the meaning, then look it up in the glossary or dictionary.
- scanning is also useful in locating statements, definitions, formulas, etc. which you must remember completely and precisely. Scan to find the exact and complete statement of a chemical law. The formula of a particular compound in chemistry, or the stages of cell division. Also, scan the charts and figures, for they usually summarize in graphic form the major ideas and facts of the chapter. Scanning can be used to look up a telephone number, read through the small adverts in a newspaper or for browsing TV or radio programmes, timetables, lists, catalogues or web pages for information. For these tasks, you don't need to read or understand every word.
- Scanning is also useful when studying or looking to find specific information from a book or article quickly as there is not always time to read every word.

Hints and Tips for better scan reading

- Don't try to read every word. Instead let your eyes move quickly across the page until you find what you are looking for.
- Use clues on the page, such as headings and titles to help you.
- If you are reading for study, start by thinking up or writing down some questions that you want to answer. Doing this can focus your mind and help you find the facts or information that you need more easily.

Skimming - Looking over the text quickly to get a general idea of the content/ the gist of something. You read quickly to get the main points, and skip over the detail. You use skimming when you are trying to decide if a book in the library or bookshop is right for you. For instance, when you spot a Communication Skill book in the library or bookshop, do you borrow/buy it without looking inside to see the topics being discussed? Most likely, you usually look inside to see whether the topics discussed therein are the ones in your course outline. Sometimes you even read the subtopics and executive summary. That process of reading the key items, just to get a rough idea of what the book, article or newspapers is talking about is called skimming.

Extensive reading/Light Reading - This is reading fairly quickly without concentrating too hard or worrying about every single word. It is often used when reading an enjoyable novel. Extensive reading is carried out to achieve a general understanding of a text. It occurs when students read large amount of high interest materials. The aims of extensive reading are to build reader's confidence and enjoyment. Extensive reading is always done for the comprehension of main ideas, not for specific details. Do you remember every single word of the last novel or story book that you read? But most likely you can remember the theme of the story, right? That reading is called extensive reading.

Intensive reading/Study Reading - it involves thinking about what is being read so that it is understood and can be recalled. It needs to be worked at, with time for reflection, thought, analysis, criticism, comparison, notes made, points highlighted and emphasized, arguments followed and evaluated, the whole summarized etc. This kind of reading calls attention to grammatical forms, discourse markers and other surface structure details for the purpose of understanding literal meaning, implications, rhetorical relationships and so on. It is detailed in-class analysis. This is the kind of reading you do when you are revising for examinations. You read with an aim to remember everything you read, even if it is word to word.

Critical Reading

Critical reading is a further dimension of in-depth reading. Reading a text critically means that you do not accept what you are reading at face value. This does not

necessarily mean that you should find fault with a text, but rather that you should question and judge the merit and worth of the information it contains.

A number of inter-related processes are involved in critical reading. They are: Interpretation, analysis, synthesis, and evaluation. Whether you use all, or only some of these processes, will depend on both the particular reading situation, and your purpose for reading.

(a) Interpretation When we read critically for interpretation, we read to discover meaning in a text, that is, to determine what conclusions can be drawn about the various messages the text contains. Sometimes, there is more than one possible interpretation, and in such cases it is possible that our reading may be directed at the best, or most likely meaning. Interpreting a text will also frequently involve the processes of analysis and synthesis.

(b) Analysis This is the process by which we examine the way the ideas and messages in a text fit together to create the overall meaning. When analyzing a text we focus on:

(i) Identifying assumptions The hidden values that underlie what a writer is saying e.g. that everyone who cleans their teeth uses toothpaste, or that anyone who loves Africa supported Ghana during the world cup matches.

(ii) (The structure of the argument The development and sequence of ideas, the relationship between ides, whether the argument is inductive or deductive.

(iii) The relationship between evidence/data and argument
Whether the evidence supports and illustrates the argument, and whether it supports any conclusions that are drawn.

c) Synthesis usually occurs in conjunction with analysis, and involves the drawing together of the results of the analysis into a conclusion on which to base an interpretation or evaluation.

Guidelines for Effective Reading

For effective reading, keep the following guidelines in mind:

Define Purpose -The objective of reading should be very specific. The reader should be clear by defining the purpose for which the matter is being read. At the same time, the

objectives for which the material is being prepared must also be seen. Careful comprehension of an individual's sense purpose will enhance the quality of his reading.

Clarity about Environment -Every reader has to understand clearly the environment in which he has to operate in. Careful understanding of internal as well as external environment will facilitate the reader to improve his efficiency.

Identify Reading Channel- The channel carries the message and thus influences the communication interaction. Books, letters, memoranda, reports, forms, newspapers and magazines are different reading channels. The reader has to identify the most effective reading channels, if he has the alternatives. It is pertinent to note that reading channels having permanent records of messages which need to be referred to.

Control Interference- For effective reading, the reader should control all potential and actual interference of people and the environment. This includes the sources of noise, disturbance, physical setting, etc. If a reader cannot control these interferences, he cannot comprehend the material effectively.

Getting the Reading of Words and Non-verbal Symbols -All messages are created by words and non-verbal symbols. Reading and comprehension skills can be enhanced by carefully assigning meanings to words and non-verbal symbols.

Evaluate Critically -A reader should keep a critical eye on the reading material. Without critical evaluation, the reader cannot carry on reading effectively. After evaluation, the reader shall be able to decide whether he needs to skim, scan or carefully read the material.

Reading Model – The SQ3R Reading technique

There are so many techniques that you can use to read for comprehension but in this lesson, we are going to concentrate on only one but very important technique that you can use to read. This technique is abbreviated as SQ3R:-

S – Survey

Q – Question

R – Read

R – Recall } 3R

R – Review

Survey – it's the rapid preview of materials in order to get an overview of a topic, chapter and books. The aim is to look for main points of the text, its content and approach.

- Read the title to help give you an idea of the subject
- Read the introduction or summary to see what the author thinks are the key point
- Peruse to see how many pages you need to read for that topic

Question – develop questioning attitude as you read. Questions help your mind to engage and concentrate because the mind is actively engaged when it's looking for answers to questions. For instance, before you read the topic on Listening Skill, you can come up with at least 4 questions i.e. "What is listening skills, why listen, how to listen effective and barriers to listening". When you start reading, you will strife to answer those questions. Every time you plan to read, especially for examinations or interviews, have some questions ready so that you can be able to tell whether you have achieved your objectives or not.

Read – after formulating questions you can start reading the materials carefully in detail. If the subject is complex, your reading may be slower but if it is simple and familiar, you adopt a faster reading.

Recall – after every section, stop, close the book and think back to your questions. See if you can answer them from memory.

Review – in case you were not able to answer from memory all the questions set, go back to the book and see where you went wrong.

Techniques for Improving Retention

Memory is the store house of our experiences and learning. It is true that all the learning cannot be stored forever, though some experiences and teachings remain forever in our memory. The following steps will improve the practical ability to retain information:

- Using Memory Aids Acronyms and abbreviations can be used as effective devices for improving retention. For example, the four P's of marketing refer to product, price, place and promotion and SWOT in strategic management refers to strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats. The seven C's of good business letter-writing are: clarity, courtesy, completeness, correctness, concreteness and coherence.

- **Deciding Priorities of Retention** The human mind has the capability to retain vast amount of information. At the same time, it is difficult to recall information from various layers of access. Hence, the closer to the surface that information lies, the earlier it is to recall the same. For this, the reader should decide his priorities of retention. Instead of retaining irrelevant information in his mind, he should store and concentrate only on priority areas.

- **Thinking** If the reader wants to retain reading material, he must think about it. If one applies the mind with regard to significance of reading material, its relationship with one's knowledge, utility for future reference etc., will automatically contribute to his retention. Linking the read material with some personal experiences and persons, helps retain the same.

- **Reinforcing** Reinforcement means to concretize in the mind, what has been read and learnt. This improves retention ability. A few tips for reinforcement are as follows:

    - ✓ Brief notes should be prepared and periodical reviews of such notes should be done.
    - ✓ After reading, the speaker should speak to someone and explain in his own words, what he has learnt.

- ✓ For improving the quality of repetitive input, the materials read should be supplemented by audio-visuals, lectures, discussions, etc.
- ✓ The read information should be related with other material and should not be considered as an end only.

- Ensuring Determination- It is rightly said, "Where there is a will there is a way." A final set of procedures for retention involves the commitment to retain knowledge. While reading, an individual may get a lot of information; but he will keep only that piece of information, which he intends to retain. If an individual does not have the will to retain, retention is impossible.

Review questions

1. Describe the concept of reading.
2. List the benefits of reading
3. Explain why do we indulge in reading
4. What factors affect reading skills?
5. Write brief notes on the following:
    a. Scanning
    b. Skimming
    c. Extensive reading
    d. Intensive reading
6. Discuss the guidelines for effective reading.
7. What is reading retention? How will you improve retention of reading material?
8. Explain the SQ3R Model of reading and its application.

9. Read the following text and make notes in such a manner that the concept is easier to retain.

    Classical conditioning is learning that takes place when we come to associate two stimuli in the environment. One of these stimuli triggers a reflexive response. The second stimulus is originally neutral with respect to that response, but after it has been paired with the first stimulus, it comes to trigger the response in its own right.